PART I

When and how do ordinary citizens gain substantial control over important collective decisions affecting their lives? This book provides new answers to this question by systematically accumulating evidence in novel ways. From calls for 'no taxation without representation' to 'defunding the police', questions regarding the authority to make and implement public spending decisions have played an important role in the imagination and practice of democracy. It is perhaps no surprise, then, that the idea and practice of participatory budgeting (PB), expanding the 'power of the purse', has garnered such interest. PB has been widely implemented by committed reformers in politics, bureaucracies and civil society, and has been studied by a number of committed scholars. The research I present here offers critical insights into when and how PB programmes succeed and fail in increasing democracy by allowing citizens greater influence over collective decisions. The work is based on bringing together the work of other scholars as well as providing a more systematic investigation of existing claims about PB using advanced comparative methods. Rather than search for further 'unique' examples of public policy innovations in the field, I bring together existing research that, in the end, provides unique insights that can only be found through such a procedure.

I show that popular claims that there are several single necessary conditions for citizens to gain such control over collective decisions have been imprudent. Successes (and, for that matter, failure) can be demonstrated where conditions that have been touted as necessary are both present and absent. Nevertheless, a political leadership committed to participation is almost always required for sustained citizen control of political decisions over the longer term. The meaningful involvement of citizens in collective governance often requires a combination of will and capacity to implement programmes from political leaders, but there is evidence that these good outcomes only occur where those willing leaders can rely on strong support and competence from

https://doi.org/10.46692/9781529209938.002 Published online by Cambridge University Press

administrative staff, or alternatively, where participatory leaders have strong fiscal independence. Perhaps controversially, the evidence for the importance of civil society conditions, which have played a strong role in theories of successful citizen participation, is mixed. Whether civil society is relevant to explanations of successful participation depends on the level of uncertainty that researchers are willing to accept in their theories, and reveals issues of conceptualization of civil society roles in participatory programmes. The evidence is less certain, but where politicians and bureaucratic staff are committed to supporting programmes, the resource capital provided by dynamic, demanding and autonomously mobilized civil society organizations (CSOs) may serve to overcome fiscal constraints. The story of PB, then, is not simply one of benign and enlightened leaders, nor simply one of power conceding nothing without a demand.

There are several possible scenarios in which participation can deepen or negate democracy, but it is certainly not a case of 'anything goes'. The absence of political leadership is almost always sufficient for disappointing participatory programmes, but where willing and capable bureaucrats are absent, combined with constraints on spending and a demobilized and placid civil society, no amount of political leadership can avoid disappointing results that are characterized by often anti-democratic politics.

The book is split into three parts. Part I explains why participatory democracy has become a key focus for politics, as PB has become the most widely adopted democratic innovation since its emergence in the late 1980s. I explain how the study of PB has developed as the concept has travelled, and elaborate on the insights from a maturing field of research. I demonstrate that a large number of high-quality and in-depth studies of PB have been produced, but their overall lessons remained unclear, until now. In Part II, I explain where our current understandings of participatory democracy are at and where they fall short, detailing the important considerations we need to take account of if we are to improve the sophistication of our accumulated knowledge. I demonstrate the value and novelty of the relatively rare medium-N analysis of 30 cases to provide insights by retaining the advantages of breadth and depth using systematic, qualitative comparative analysis (QCA). In Part III I present evidence using QCA to systematically review existing material on PB to answer three questions: what conditions are necessary and sufficient for citizen control of PB and negation of citizen control of PB? What is left unanswered by the data we have accumulated? In light of the findings, how should we now

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understand the value of democratic innovation and its implications for theories of democracy?

In the final chapter of the book I turn to outline the implications of comparing democratic innovations for democratic reform. I widen the scope of the argument to insist that a better comparative method in social sciences is crucial to a better policy science of evidence-based practice. Policymaking in an era of networked governance sometimes suffers both from increased pressures and opportunities to innovate. This 'innovation' requires vigilance among political scientists and policy learners interested in classifying phenomena, providing explanations and understanding what should be done to buttress democracy. Where we are attracted to understand cases because of the seemingly unique stories they tell, it raises the question of how we can build on in-depth knowledge to provide systematic evidence for our theories. The book therefore also seeks to address practically the important issues raised when political reforms are recognized for their exceptional characteristics and policy analysts wish to move beyond the lessons of one or two strong exemplars.

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